

FREE TEMPLATE

The AI Automation Starter Checklist

Seven steps to find, build, and ship your first AI automation — without hiring a developer or rebuilding your whole workflow.

1 List every repetitive task you do by hand

Spend one week jotting down anything you (or your team) do more than once a week: copying data between apps, replying to the same questions, chasing invoices, posting the same kind of update. This list is your automation backlog.

2 Pick the task that costs you the most time — not the flashiest one

Sort your list by hours spent per month, not by how impressive it sounds. The most valuable first automation is usually the most boring one.

3 Map the tools already involved

Write down every app that task touches (a form, a spreadsheet, an inbox, a calendar). Most automations are just those tools talking to each other — you rarely need to build anything from scratch.

4 Sketch the flow in three boxes: trigger → action → result

Before opening any tool, describe it in one sentence: “When X happens, do Y, and end up with Z.” If you can't say it in one sentence, the task is too big to automate in one step — split it.

5 Build the smallest version first

Use a no-code platform (Make, Zapier, n8n) to connect the first trigger to the first action. Get one real run working end to end before adding branches, filters, or extra steps.

6 Test it with real data, on purpose

Run it with a real (or realistic) example and check every downstream step — not just that it ran, but that the output is something you'd be comfortable sending to a client.

7 Set a reminder to revisit it in 30 days

The first version is rarely the last. Revisit after a month to fix edge cases, tighten the wording, and decide whether it's ready to expand.

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